

the upper-class version of early 20th century history, we are shown a different (and extremely exciting) world that can offer audience from this area, or from this class, a more authentic text to identify with.

Gender performativity – Judith Butler

- Butler asserts that gender is not a fixed biologically determined characteristic, but rather a fluid **social construct**. She suggests people ‘**perform**’ a gender role composed of clothes, hair/make-up, posture and other behaviours.
- Costume is crucial in *Peaky Blinders* for constructing not just gender, but also status and power. The Peaky Blinders themselves wear expensive sharp suits (upper class), with flat caps (working class), that also turn into weapons (aggressive masculinity). This costume announces their masculinity as being dominating, territorial and violent.
- Grace is an interesting representation of ‘performed’ femininity. She deliberately dresses more ‘girlish’ and innocent when she first goes for the job at the pub. Her singing is also soft, emotional and melodic. Later, it is revealed this is just a performance and she is actually a vengeful and driven undercover agent.
- Consider the costumes, postures, hair, makeup and dialogue of the male and female characters. How do they ‘perform’ different considering masculine and feminine roles? Who are they performing them to (i.e. trying to convince)? Where do we see ‘cracks’ in these gender performances?

PART 3: STARTING POINTS – Media industries

Consider the processes of production, distribution and circulation by organisations, groups, and individuals in a global context.

- *Peaky Blinders* is a **co-production** between Caryn Mandabach productions, Tiger Aspect (both independent) and Yorkshire Screen Fund. The show was the first to receive a grant from Yorkshire Screen Content Fund, set up to promote production and representation of the county.

- The show was created by Steven Knight, who grew up in the Small Heath area of Birmingham. Knight had previously written several successful film and TV titles, including *Dirty Pretty Things*, *Hummingbird* and *Eastern Promises* – these are also crime dramas with strong characterisation and explorations of social issues including national and class identity. His name on the project was a major draw for production companies and finance.
- *Peaky Blinders* was distributed by the Weinstein Company in the USA but, in the wake of the #MeToo movement’s revelations, the rights were sold to Netflix. This has exposed the show to a far wider global market.
- *Peaky Blinders* would be good example of Netflix’s commitment to ‘**telling local stories on a global platform**’, i.e. commissioning or purchasing content based in a very specific location and culture, that also has international appeal. The Korean show *Squid Game* is another good example of this.
- Consider how a UK audience may respond to the show, and then consider how might a non-UK audience (particularly in non-English speaking territories) respond to the plot and themes? Some ideas: what elements of the narrative are universal (you may want to refer to **Vladimir Propp’s ‘narratemes’** here)? What themes and issues may appeal to audiences from different cultures? What values might be shared (e.g. loyalty to family in the face of adversity)?

Consider the significance of economic factors to media industries and their products.

- As a **public service broadcaster** and non-profit institution, the BBC isn’t constrained by the commercial model of other broadcast TV in the UK. Instead of ‘playing it safe’ by repeating popular concepts or genres, it has a responsibility to develop fresh and unique content and diverse voices.
- The Midlands, much neglected by TV production, has been a key area of investment for the BBC, who has been shifting their studios and other offices from London to Manchester and other northern cities since 2011.